

COOKING UP A STORM

REBEL FOODS

Founded: 2011

Total funding:

\$527.3 million

Speciality: **Multi-brand cloud kitchen**

Customers: **Wendy's, Naturals, Mad Over Donuts, SLAY Coffee**



MUKUNDA FOODS

Founded: 2012

Total funding:

\$9.1 million

Speciality:

Kitchen robotics

Customers: **ITC, Wow! Momo, Chaayos, Zomato**

GHOST KITCHEN INDIA

Founded: 2019

Total funding:

\$1.2 million

Speciality:

Multi-brand cloud kitchen

In-house brands:

Starboy Pizza & Shakes, Wakka Makka, MomoGuy, Badmash Biryani

are set to be a \$2-billion industry in India by 2024, up from \$400 million in 2019.

Meanwhile, Mumbai-based Ghost Kitchen India has a portfolio of 30 in-house food delivery brands, including Starboy Pizza & Shakes, New York Waffles & Dinges and Wakka Makka, across cuisine categories. "Technology is heavily influencing the food delivery industry. [It plays a big role] in our operations," says Karan Tanna, Founder and CEO of Ghost Kitchen India. Apart from robotics, AI is used to predict the amount of ingredients to be used in a particular recipe. Similarly, ML and open data are key tools that enable access to real-time and aggregated data visibility that helps in inventory or stock management.

Tanna says foodtech is not only about leveraging discovery platforms but also using tech that is customised to your operations. "We use AI to predict the requirement of raw material in our kitchen so that we never run out of them; the availability ratio of menu items is always targeted above 95 per cent. Now it's not only about food, but also about how to best leverage the customer who shops online and deliver him the experience that increases the stickiness of the brand," he says.

Rebel Foods, a Mumbai-based company that operates over 45 cloud kitchen brands including Faasos and Behrouz Biryani, uses software, robotics and automation for food preparation. The company uses a lot of embedded

systems, AI, and IoT in collaboration with its partners. "We are also building smart kitchen appliances and machinery that are already operational in the kitchens. We are also developing machines that understand recipes," says Prakash Dutta, Global COO, Rebel Foods. For instance, the company uses a rotating wok that simulates a chef's stir-frying motion. The wok also controls the temperature and the amount of oil dispensed. Dutta says the company has also attached a video screen and an app to the wok. At different stages of cooking, the machine instructs the chef when to add the different ingredients as per the recipe. "While chefs will come and go at Rebel Foods, intelligent robots are passing down recipes," says Dutta, adding that these machines enable the company to run multiple brands—including those of its partners—from the same kitchen. "The future of food is very exciting—deep personalisation, automation, farm to fork tracing, complete transparency, and safety," adds Dutta.

Well, it looks like the Food Replicator isn't too far into the future. **BT**

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